Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Butler Yeats's "The Scholars"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a comparison between young poets and older scholars and their differing understandings of love in Yeats's "The Scholars" includes

allusion,
anaphora,
consonance,
masculine rhyme,
metonymy,
rhetorical question,
slant rhyme,
speaker,
synecdoche,
tetrameter,
theme,
tone,
vehicle, and
visual imagery.

Any response to the prompt will focus on the difference between experiencing love and researching the experience of love, which, in the speaker's estimation can be recognized in the difference between a young man's composition of a poem for the woman he loves and an older man's critical response to that endeavor.

The query regarding an aged Catullus (line 12) does not need to be addressed; however, were an inference drawn, the question whether the fervid aspects of youthful love (lines 4-6) become foci for literary critics, the scholars (line 3), beyond the ability to experience, to know, love as youth does points to the young contestant's recognition of something toward an irony: in short, a lesson.